BRCGS

Global Standard
FOOD SAFETY
ISSUE 9

MODULE 11
MEAT SUPPLY CHAIN ASSURANCE

Developed in association with

bmpa

brcgs.com

Copyright and Liability

BRCGS publishes information and expresses opinions in good faith but accepts no liability for any error or omission in any such information or opinion, including any information or opinion contained in this publication.

Whilst BRCGS has endeavoured to ensure that the information in this publication is accurate, it shall not be liable for any damages (including without limitation damages for pure economic loss or loss of business or loss of profits or depletion of goodwill or otherwise in each case, whether direct, indirect or consequential) or any claims for consequential compensation whatsoever (howsoever caused) arising in contract, tort (including negligence or breach of statutory duty), misrepresentation, restitution or otherwise, in connection with this publication or any information contained in it, or from any action or decision taken as a result of reading this publication or any such information.

All warranties, conditions and other terms implied by statute or common law are, to the fullest extent permitted by law, excluded.

Nothing excludes or limits the liability of BRCGS for death or personal injury caused by its negligence, for fraud or fraudulent misrepresentation or for any matter which it would be illegal for it to exclude or attempt to exclude liability for.

The Global Standard Food Safety (Issue 9), Module 11: Meat Supply Chain Assurance and the terms of the disclaimer set out above shall be construed in accordance with English law and shall be subject to the non-exclusive jurisdiction of the English Courts.

© 2022 BRCGS
ISBN: 978-1-78490-461-6

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be transmitted or reproduced in any form (including photocopying or storage in any medium by electronic means) without the written permission of the copyright owner. Application for permission should be addressed to the Head of Publishing at BRCGS (contact details below). Full acknowledgement of the author and source must be given.

The contents of this publication cannot be reproduced for the purposes of training or any other commercial activity.

No part of this publication may be translated without the written permission of the copyright owner.

Warning: Any unauthorised act in relation to a copyright work may result in both a civil claim for damages and criminal prosecution.

Published by:
BRCGS
Second Floor
7 Harp Lane
London EC3R 6DP

Tel: +44 (0) 20 3931 8150
Email: publishing@brcgs.com
brcgs.com

For more information about BMPA, contact:
BMPA
17 Clerkenwell Green
London, EC1R 0DP

Tel: +44 (0) 20 7329 0776
Fax: +44 (0) 20 7329 0653
Email: info@bmpa.uk.com
Website: www.bmpa.uk.com

Design and typeseting by Vital Creative, St. Leonards-on-Sea.

Contents

Part I Audit protocol

Background and objective 4
Scope 4
Exclusions from scope 4
Audit planning 5
Preparation by the company 5
Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation 5
Audit duration 5
The on-site audit 5
Standalone audit to the Module 5
Non-conformities and corrective action 6
Non-conformities 6
Procedures for handling non-conformities and corrective action 6
Critical non-conformities 6
Major and minor non-conformities 6
Grading 7
Audit reporting 7
Certification 7
Ongoing audit frequency and recertification 7
Scheduling re-audit dates 7
Phased introduction of clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2 7
Year 1 – Initial audit to the Module (sites not currently certificated to the Module) 8
Year 2 – First re-audit to the Module at the certificated site (recertification audit) 8
Year 3 – Second re-audit to the Module at the certificated site (recertification audit) 8

Part II Requirements

Relationship of the Module to the Standard 9
11 Requirements of Module 11: Meat Supply Chain Assurance 9
11.1 Traceability 9
11.2 Approval of the meat supply chain 11
11.3 Raw material receipt and inspection 14
11.4 Management of cross-contamination between species 14
11.5 Product testing 16
11.6 Training 17

Appendix 1: The relationship between the facility and their tiered suppliers

18

Part 1
Introduction

Background and objective

The meat-processing industry has been under a higher level of public scrutiny following a series of fraudulent claims relating to meat products, including the substitution of beef by horsemeat in Europe. Customers of meat-processing facilities have, as a consequence, requested increased transparency of meat supply chains with demonstrable systems of traceability back to the slaughterhouse and the verification of authenticity. This resulted in a significant increase in audits throughout the meat supply chain.

Module 11 Meat Supply Chain Assurance (hereafter referred to as 'the Module') has been developed in response to requests from the meat supply chain and its customers and was initiated by the British Meat Processors Association (BMPA) to reduce the audit burden on the meat sector.

Certification to this additional module in association with the BRCGS Global Standard Food Safety (Issue 9) (hereafter referred to as the Standard) is designed to:

- demonstrate good management of the meat supply chain
- provide confidence to customers
- reduce the need for multiple audits of the supply chain
- reduce costs and audit time for meat processors
- ensure a consistent quality to meat supply chain auditing.

Scope

The use of the module is voluntary but it is applicable to manufacturing facilities that use the following as a raw material in the production of meat or meat preparations*:

- red meat, poultry and/or game
- further processed meat products
- offal of red meat and poultry.

It is not necessary for standalone slaughterhouses themselves to be certificated to the Module, unless they are processing products that were not slaughtered on site. This is because the requirements for slaughterhouses are fully covered by the requirements in Issue 9 (for example, section 11.1 of the Module requires full supply chain traceability including a supply chain map. However, a slaughterhouse will receive animals directly from farm(s) and this single-step traceability is fully covered by section 3.9 of the Standard).

Exclusions from scope

Where the Module is requested, the scope is intended to include all of the applicable meat and meat preparations. By exception, sites handling multiple species of meat may ask for specific meat species to be excluded from the audit scope (for example, a site handling lamb and beef could request an audit scope covering beef products with an exclusion for lamb products). Note that it is not possible to exclude products on any other basis, such as geographic origin or country of sale of final product.

Where an exclusion is agreed, clauses in sections 11.1, 11.2 and 11.5 will apply only to the meat species that are within the audit scope. The remaining sections (11.3, 11.4 and 11.6) will continue to apply to all meat species on site.

* Meat and meat preparations include whole carcasses, cuts of meat (including those reduced to fragments) and meat that has had foodstuffs, seasonings or additives added to it. The internal muscle fibre structure of the meat (the characteristics of fresh meat) has been retained (as, for example, in fresh cuts of meat, minced meat, sausages and pies containing meat).

Where exclusions are requested they shall be agreed with the certification body in advance of the audit. Exclusions shall be clearly stated on the audit report and certificate.

The Module is not intended to apply to meat derivatives such as gelatine, meat stocks etc.

Audit planning

Preparation by the company

The certification body shall be notified in advance of the audit of the intention to add the Module to the scope of the audit. This ensures that sufficient additional time can be scheduled and that an auditor with the appropriate qualifications for the additional module is selected.

Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation

The company shall supply the certification body with any additional background information requested prior to the audit day to ensure that the auditor is fully prepared to audit against the Module. This is likely to include information on the:

- types of raw materials to be included within the scope
- number of suppliers used to source the products.

Audit duration

In order for the Module to be included within the audit programme, additional time will be needed for the audit. The amount of additional time will depend upon the number of raw materials included, the number of suppliers, and the length of the supply chain, but would typically be 2–4 hours of additional time. The certification body shall indicate the expected additional time requirements at the time of planning the audit.

The on-site audit

Compliance with the requirements of the Module is normally assessed as part of the audit against the requirement of the Standard and is expected to be integrated into the audit programme as appropriate.

During the audit, detailed notes shall be made regarding the site's conformities and non-conformities against the requirements of the additional module, and these will be used as the basis for an addendum to the audit report. The auditor(s) shall assess the nature and severity of any non-conformity.

At the closing meeting, the auditor(s) shall present their findings and discuss all non-conformities that have been identified against the Module during the audit. A written summary of the non-conformities discussed at the closing meeting will be documented by the auditor either at the closing meeting or within 1 working day after completion of the audit.

The decision to award certification for the Module will be determined independently by the certification body management, following a technical review of the audit report and the closing of non-conformities in the appropriate timeframe. The company will be informed of the certification decision following this review.

The Module can be audited as part of an announced or unannounced audit.

Standalone audit to the Module

By exception, where it is not possible to undertake the audit for the Module at the same time as the audit for the Standard, a return visit to the site, not in combination with the Standard audit, may be made by the same auditor who undertook the audit for the Standard.

In this case, it is recommended that the audit is planned for 3.5 hours (half a day) in duration, and the auditor should both assess the Module requirements and reassess the relevant aspects of the Standard where needed, as specified in Part II. If the traceability tests are not completed within the duration of the audit the site will need to ensure that the relevant information is forwarded to the auditor within the time period permitted for the traceability test (as detailed in clause 11.1.3).

Non-conformities and corrective action

The level of non-conformity assigned by an auditor against a requirement of the Module is an objective judgement with respect to severity and risk and is based on evidence collected and observations made during the audit. This is verified by the certification body management.

Non-conformities

Non-conformities against requirements of this module shall be graded in the same way as non-conformities identified against requirements of the Standard, namely:

- **Critical** Where there is a critical failure to comply with a product safety or legal issue within the scope of the Module.
- **Major** Where there is a substantial failure to meet the requirements of a 'statement of intent' or any clause of the Module or a situation is identified which would, on the basis of available objective evidence, raise significant doubt as to the conformity of the product or service to the Module.
- **Minor** Where a clause of the Module has not been fully met but, on the basis of objective evidence, the conformity of the product to the Module is not in doubt.

Procedures for handling non-conformities and corrective action

Following identification of any non-conformities against the requirements of the Module during the audit, the company must undertake corrective action to remedy the immediate issue (correction). The process for 'closing out' non-conformities depends upon the level of non-conformity and the number of non-conformities identified.

Critical non-conformities

If a critical non-conformity is identified against a requirement of the Module, then the site cannot be certificated for this module without a further full audit of the Module.

Where this occurs at a site that already holds certification for the Module, this certification must be immediately withdrawn.

If it is a requirement of customers that they shall be informed when their suppliers have a critical non-conformity identified or fail to gain certification against a module, the company shall immediately inform its customers.

Note a critical non-conformity against a requirement of a module does not necessarily prevent certification against the Standard or other additional modules.

Major and minor non-conformities

The Module cannot be included on a certificate until major and minor non-conformities have been demonstrated as having been corrected, either permanently or via a temporary solution that is acceptable to the certification body.

Close-out of non-conformities can be achieved either by objective evidence being submitted to the certification body, such as updated procedures, records, photographs or invoices for work undertaken, or by the certification body undertaking a further on-site visit.

If satisfactory evidence is not provided within the 28-calendar-day period allowed for submission following the audit, certification for the Module will not be granted. The site will then require a further full audit in order to be considered for certification of the Module.

The certification body will review objective evidence of corrective action completed prior to awarding a certificate.

Grading

There will be no grading of the Module. The Module will either be certificated or not.

Any non-conformities identified when assessing the Module shall not be taken into account when deciding the grade for certification against the Standard.

Audit reporting

Following each audit, a written report shall be prepared in the agreed format for the Module and this will form an addendum to the Standard audit report. The addendum report shall be produced in English or in another language, dependent upon user needs. Where the report is produced in a language other than English, any applicable audit summary sections shall, in addition, always be reported in English.

The report addendum shall be prepared and dispatched to the company following the same rules as the report for the Standard (Issue 9 Part III, sections 2.5). Where the audit has been completed as a standalone audit rather than in conjunction with the audit of the Standard, the Module shall be reported using the standalone module report.

The full audit report, together with the addendum for the Module, shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory in a timely manner irrespective of whether a certificate is issued. The owner of the audit report may allocate access to the audit report with the addendum to customers or other parties in the Directory.

The audit report and associated documentation, including the auditor's notes, shall be stored safely and securely for a period of 5 years by the certification body.

Certification

After a review of the audit report for the Module and documentary evidence provided in relation to the non-conformities identified, a certification decision shall be made by the designated independent certification manager.

Note that the Modules are certificated separately from the Standard; however, where certification to the Standard is not achieved, certification for the Module cannot be awarded, irrespective of whether the requirements of the Module have been met.

Ongoing audit frequency and recertification

Scheduling re-audit dates

If certification to the Module is to be maintained, the Module shall be included within each subsequent audit of the Standard. The rules for scheduling the next audit and maintaining certification will follow the audit choice for the Standard (i.e. announced, unannounced or blended).

Phased introduction of clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2

When a site initially elects to be certificated to the Module there may be specific challenges for sites with extensive meat supply chains. This is because at the start of the process much of the supply chain may not be certificated to the Module and would therefore need to be audited to comply with requirement 11.2.2.

In order for the Module to achieve its goals of better supply chain assurance and reduction in audits for meat processors, the following 3-year process will apply when sites are initially certificated to the Module.

Year 1 – Initial audit to the Module (sites not currently certificated to the Module)

Clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2 shall be applicable only to immediate suppliers processing meat-based ingredients (Tier 1) and any intermediate cold stores/agents and brokers, between the processor/manufacturer and the site being audited to the Module.

The scope of the audit on the audit report shall define the meat species processed and include the wording 'immediate suppliers only Tier 1'. For example:

'Beef and lamb: immediate suppliers only Tier 1'.

Year 2 – First re-audit to the Module at the certificated site (recertification audit)

Clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2 shall be applicable only to immediate (Tier 1) and secondary (Tier 2) meat processing suppliers and any intermediate cold stores/agents and brokers, between the Tier 2 processor/manufacturer and the site being audited to the Module.

The scope of the audit on the audit report shall define the meat species processed and include the wording 'immediate and secondary suppliers Tiers 1 and 2'. For example:

'Beef and lamb: immediate and secondary suppliers Tiers 1 and 2'.

Year 3 – Second re-audit to the Module at the certificated site (recertification audit)

In year 3, clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2 shall apply to the full supply chain.

The scope of the audit on the audit report shall define the meat species processed and include the wording 'full supply chain'. For example:

'Beef and lamb: full supply chain'.

Diagrammatic representation of the tiers is shown in Appendix 1.

Part II
Requirements

Relationship of the Module to the Standard

Certification to this module can be achieved only if the site is fully compliant with the requirements of the Standard. All applicable clauses of the Standard shall include provision for this module to achieve certification to the Module. The list below shows some examples of applicable clauses.

3.1	Food safety and quality manual
3.2	Document control
3.3	Record completion and maintenance
3.4	Internal audits
3.7	Corrective and preventive actions
3.8	Control of non-conforming product
3.9	Traceability
3.10	Complaint-handling
3.11	Management of incidents, product withdrawal and product recall
5.4	Product authenticity, claims and chain of custody
7.1	Training: raw material handling, preparation, processing, packing and storage areas

11 Requirements of Module 11: Meat Supply Chain Assurance

The site shall be able to trace all meat-based raw materials back to the place of slaughter.

11.1 Traceability

Clause	Requirements
11.1.1	There shall be a supply chain map for all meat raw materials, which identifies each storage and processing facility in the full supply chain back to the place of slaughter. This shall include the: • site and company name • address • appropriate registrations with the relevant authorities - e.g., health mark type of operation (i.e. slaughter, cutting etc.) • species handled. Where agents or brokers are used at any point in the supply chain, these shall be identified.
Interpretation	The intent of the supply chain map is to identify the full supply chain for each meat raw material back to the place of slaughter. It is likely that some suppliers will have a number of alternative suppliers and each should be included on the supply chain map. Some customers may stipulate specific supply chains for their products. The supply chain map will need to be kept up to date and will be tested at the audit by means of the traceability exercise. Information from the supply chain map also enables the potential risks of cross-contamination between species to be understood.

Clause	Requirements
11.1.2	Where the product or ingredient has a specific provenance or scheme claim (e.g. breed, origin, method of production), traceability shall be in place at a level to verify the source of the provenance or scheme claim (e.g. to a farm or group of farms).
Interpretation	This clause covers claims of provenance or scheme, not nutritional quality (e.g. low fat). Claims may include origin (e.g. New Zealand lamb, Argentinian beef), breed (e.g. Aberdeen Angus beef) and method of production (e.g. free-range chicken, organic). The definition of the expected requirements to meet the claim must be clear and comply with any legal requirements where these occur. The traceability exercise must be sufficiently extensive to demonstrate support for the claim, which may include traceability to the farm or individual animals. Reference to the claim should be present on product labels and delivery notes accompanying the product at the point of receipt on site. Work in progress must be clearly identifiable.
11.1.3	The site shall test the traceability system for a lot code of meat/meat preparation received on site back to the slaughter plant, including any intermediate processing and/or storage facilities and/or transportation where used. The traceability exercise shall be carried out at least once every 6 months, and the results shall be retained for inspection. As a guide, it should be possible to achieve traceability within 4 hours of notification at each point in the supply chain or 24 hours where the supplier is in a different time zone.
Interpretation	The product selected for the test should be in the supply chain for a sufficient number of stages to effectively test the ability of the chain to provide the required information. The site is expected to select a different product/supply chain/source/species each time the traceability test is completed to ensure that, over a defined period of time, all the different supply chains used by the site have been tested. During the audit, the auditor will therefore expect traceability test results to be available for different products. Each company in the supply chain would be expected to be able to trace and identify its suppliers in turn within 4 hours of notification. However suppliers in different time zones would be expected to complete the traceability within 24 hours of receipt, regardless of the time differences. Records of the timings for each step in the traceability should be retained as part of the traceability documentation. The traceability exercise should be completed in a timely manner, unless there are justifiable circumstances for a delay. Examples include if the region has suffered a natural or unnatural disaster, preventing the data from being collated or sent; if it is a national holiday in the country or region where the service provider's office is based; or if a time zone difference means that it is already a non- working day, such as a weekend. Where traceability takes longer than the expected time, areas where the retrieval of information is slow should be reviewed to identify improvements. In addition to the 6-monthly traceability challenge undertaken by the site, the auditor will also select at least one raw material for a traceability test as part of the audit. The auditor has the option to request additional traceability tests where concerns are raised during the audit or initial traceability test. Where a site has multiple schemes or customers, it is not intended that every scheme or customer product be tested every 6 months but that a representative selections are chosen. In this situation, good practice would be to choose different scheme or customer each time the test is conducted. All records associated with product safety, integrity or legality should be retained for an appropriate period (see clause 3.3.2 of the Standard and the Interpretation Guideline for additional information).

Clause	Requirements
11.1.4	The site shall carry out a documented mass-balance traceability exercise for a meat ingredient both forwards from raw material to finished product and backwards from a finished product to raw material. The test shall be carried out at least once per year, and the results retained for inspection. The mass-balance exercise shall take into consideration any scheme requirements include any wastage and processing yield losses to account for the full batch.
Interpretation	The mass-balance traceability exercise should be carried out for a product of sufficient complexity to effectively challenge the traceability and recording system of the site. Wastage and processing yield figures need to be demonstrably accurate. The forward traceability test should identify a batch of meat-based raw material and be able to identify all the finished products manufactured from that batch of raw material, including the finished product batch code and weight of the raw material used in each batch. Where a site has multiple schemes or customers, it is not intended that every scheme or customer product needs to be tested but that a representative selections are chosen. In this situation, good practice would be to choose different scheme or customer each time the test is conducted. Legislation and customer requirements relating to meat products often include considerable traceability requirements such as accounting for waste materials. It is therefore important that sites understand these requirements when assessing the effectiveness of traceability and mass-balance tests. Sites should always seek to achieve 100% accuracy in mass-balance testing. Where this level of accuracy is not achieved, the reasons should be recorded, and where appropriate investigated.

11.2 Approval of the meat supply chain

The company shall have an effective supplier-approval system that covers all suppliers in the meat supply chain (including cold stores, agents, brokers and processors) back to and including the place of slaughter to ensure that any potential risks to the safety, authenticity legality and quality of the product supplied are understood and managed.

Clause	Requirements
11.2.1	The company shall undertake a documented risk assessment of its meat supply chain and use this as the basis for its product acceptance and testing procedures. This shall cover all suppliers in the meat supply chain, including any cold stores (storage locations), agents and brokers, back to and including the slaughter plant. Factors that should be considered when assessing the risk include: • the nature of the product (e.g. primal, minced, further processed) • processes undertaken at the facility (e.g. storage, processing, tempering) • the opportunity for cross-contamination between products of different species • the opportunity for adulteration • packaging format and security of the product from contamination or substitution • the country where the facility is located and any legislative controls • customer-specific requirements • legislative requirements in the country of sale or importation of the product.

Clause	Requirements
Interpretation	The procedure must cover all suppliers of meat in the supply chain, including processors, storage facilities and agents or brokers as applicable. To do this effectively requires an understanding of the supply chain and the activities undertaken at each stage. A cold store that undertakes tempering, freezing or relabelling may present a greater risk than a cold store that only stores and distributes the packaged product. Lists of meat-processing plants with EU approval, together with the species for which approval has been granted, are publicly available and these can be a useful resource. The results of the risk assessment shall be used not only to define supplier approval procedures but also to specify the level of sampling or testing of materials on receipt. Any raw-material testing for cross-contamination between species should be based on the opportunities for cross-contamination in the supply chain. Good practice is to ensure that the risk assessment remains up to date and reflects, for example, any change to the product or supply chain, or the emergence of a newly identified risk. As noted in the audit protocol, sites can phase in compliance to this clause during the first 3 years of certification to the Module (see 'Phased introduction of clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2' in Part I).

11.2.2	The process for the initial and ongoing approval of each step in the meat supply chain shall include evidence of an audit of that part of the supply chain operation.
	
	For facilities in the supply chain that handle open or incompletely packaged products (i.e. where the packaging is insufficient to prevent any risk of species-to-species cross-contamination), the approval procedure shall include:
	
	• a valid certification to the appropriate BRCGS Standard and include this module. The scope of certification shall include the raw materials purchased
	or
	• supplier audits with a scope that includes product safety, traceability testing, Hazard Analysis and Critical Control Point (HACCP) or food safety plan, product security and food defence plan, product authenticity plan and good manufacturing practices, including evidence of compliance with the requirements of this module including species. The audit shall ensure that these plans form part of the supplier's product safety management system and that any resultant actions are implemented. The audits shall be annual and undertaken by an experienced and demonstrably competent product safety auditor. Where the supplier audit is completed by a second or third party, the company shall be able to:
	  • demonstrate the competence of the auditor
	  • confirm that the scope of the audit includes product safety, traceability testing (see clause 11.1.3), HACCP systems, product security and food defence plan, product authenticity and good manufacturing practices, including evidence of compliance with the requirements of this module
	  • obtain and review a copy of the full audit report.
	
	For agents or brokers and storage facilities handling fully enclosed products, the approval procedure shall include:
	
	• a valid certification to the BRCGS Global Standard Agents and Brokers or BRCGS Global Standard Storage and Distribution (or an equivalent GFSI-benchmarked standard). The scope of certification shall include the raw materials purchased

Clause	Requirements

	or
	• an audit with a scope that includes product safety, traceability, testing, supplier approval, HACCP or food safety plan or equivalent systems, product security and food defence plan, product authenticity and good operating practices. The audit shall be annual and undertaken by an experienced and demonstrably competent product safety auditor. Where the audit is completed by a second or third party, the company shall be able to:
	  • demonstrate the competence of the auditor
	  • confirm that the scope of the audit includes product safety, traceability testing, HACCP or food safety plan, product security and food defence, product authenticity good manufacturing practices, including evidence of compliance with the requirements of this module
	  • obtain and review a copy of the full audit report.

Interpretation	The site will need evidence of the certification status or completion of the appropriate audit for each supplier in the supply chain map. Where a site in the middle of a supply chain can demonstrate certification to the Standard and this module, then its suppliers can be assumed to be compliant without the need for further audit information to be passed to its customers. Where sites handling open product or processing the meat products supplied have a BRCGS certificate but are not yet certificated to this module, compliance with the requirements of this module must be sought and verified. Where the audits have been carried out by a non-BRCGS auditor the qualifications of the auditor must be made available and the audit report needs to clearly demonstrate how the criteria within this module have been met. Any such audits must be carried out annually to be in line with comparable GFSI audits. As noted in the audit protocol, sites can phase in compliance with this clause during the first 3 years of certification to the Module (see 'Phased introduction of clauses 11.2.1 and 11.2.2' in Part 1).
11.2.3	The procedures shall define how exceptions to the supplier approval process in clause 11.2.2 are handled (e.g. where a raw material supply chain is prescribed by a customer and an audit of the site is not practical prior to first purchase) and instead product testing or additional supplier approval controls are used to verify product safety, authenticity, legality and quality. When a site produces customer-branded product, the relevant exceptions shall be identified to the customer.
Interpretation	In cases where it is impossible to operate the approval processes in clause 11.2.2 (e.g. emergency supplies where an established supplier is unable to fulfil an order or purchases from a supplier prescribed by a customer), the site must have a procedure detailing how these exceptions are handled. The process should include an assessment of the risk of the purchase and the completion of additional supplier approval, appropriate checks or tests to mitigate any risk. The Standard does not specify the maximum or minimum length of time for which a raw material or supplier may be treated as an exception, as this will depend on the cause of the situation. For example, it may be a one-off purchase to fulfil a customer order or a longer period to address supply during an incident affecting the normal supply chain or country of origin. Where the materials are used to produce a customer-branded product, the exceptions must be communicated to the customer.

11.3 Raw material receipt and inspection

Acceptance procedures for meat-based raw materials shall ensure the integrity of packaging and label information.

Clause	Requirements
11.3.1	Procedures shall be in place for the inspection of meat-based raw materials on receipt. The procedures shall ensure that: • the supplier of the raw material and, where applicable, the intermediate cold store, are on the approved supplier list. Registrations, and other indicators of origin on the packaging shall be reconciled against the supplier map • the packaging is intact and there are no signs of damage or interference. Tamper-evident seals on the packaging or vehicles/containers are intact • the label information includes batch code information enabling full traceability of the meat products and any claims.
Interpretation	Where the product has come from a cold store rather than directly from the supplier, the approval status of the cold store as well as the processor shall be verified. Checks on incoming product must include labelling information to ensure that there are clear batch codes and that claims are identified on the label. Registrations, as appropriate, should be present and indicate production by an approved plant, as identified on the supplier map. Records of the checks and information shall be retained (see clause 3.3.2 of the Standard) for further information on retention of records.

11.4 Management of cross-contamination between species

Where sites process meat from more than one species, there shall be a system for the management of processing operations which minimises the risk of cross-contamination of one species by another.

Clause	Requirements
11.4.1	The site shall have a list of meat-based raw materials and the meat species contained in them.
Interpretation	This applies to all composite raw materials containing meat and mixed meat products, but is not applicable to single-species meat labelled with the meat species. Raw material specifications should be a reliable source of information for confirming the relevant material and meat species (see clauses 3.6.2 and 3.6.4 in the Standard).
11.4.2	A documented risk assessment shall be carried out to identify all routes of cross-contamination between species. This will inform policies and procedures for handling raw materials, intermediate products and finished products so that cross-contamination is avoided. This shall include: • the identification of potential points of cross-contamination through the process flow • an assessment of the risk of cross-contamination between species at each process step • the identification of suitable controls to reduce or eliminate the risk of cross-contamination between species.

Clause	Requirements
Interpretation	The study needs to include all the steps in the process, from receipt of raw material through to the handling, processing, storage and dispatch of the final product. Processes to prevent cross-contamination between species need to be focused on points where the product is not packaged. The risk assessment should form the basis for the development of procedures to prevent cross-contamination (see clause 11.4.3). For single-species plants, this clause would be not applicable.
11.4.3	Documented procedures shall be established to ensure the effective management of activities to prevent cross-contamination between products of different species. This may include as appropriate: • physical segregation, with processing lines dedicated to the products of a single species • use of identified, dedicated equipment, personal protective equipment and utensils for processing a single-species product • scheduling of production to reduce changes between processing products of different species or products containing different species on the same lines or equipment • effective cleaning of equipment between productions of different species • segregated storage of different species where products are not packaged sufficiently to prevent cross-contamination.
Interpretation	The approaches taken to prevent cross-contamination will depend upon the level of risk but must be clearly defined and appropriately implemented. Analytical techniques can detect minute levels of cross-contamination and may lead to false claims of adulteration. The processes should aim to prevent this.
11.4.4	Equipment and area-cleaning procedures shall be designed to remove or reduce to acceptable levels any potential cross-contamination between products of different species. The cleaning methods shall be validated to ensure that they are effective and the effectiveness of the procedure shall be routinely verified. Cleaning equipment shall either be identifiable and specific for a single species or single use, or effectively cleaned after use.
Interpretation	The acceptable level of cleaning must be defined; this should, for example, include consideration of any requirements set by authorities in the country of sale or by specific customers. Where claims are made or where cross-contamination has a greater significance cleaning to the lowest detectable level using currently available DNA testing methodology shall apply. For example, cross-contamination of halal products with pork.
11.4.5	Where rework is used, or reworking operations are carried out, procedures shall be implemented to ensure that rework containing one species is not used in products that do not already contain that species. Where customers have specific requirements for rework, these shall be identified in production specifications and implemented accordingly.

Clause	Requirements
Interpretation	Specific documented procedures must operate to prevent rework containing one species of meat from being used in products or processes that do not contain that species. Best practice is that rework is used on a 'like for like' basis (i.e. it is used only in exactly the same product). The use of rework must be documented.
11.4.6	The company shall provide clear guidelines on any restrictions to the scope of new product developments to control the introduction of new species of meat to the site. All new meat products and changes to the methods of processing of meat products shall be formally approved by the HACCP team leader or authorised HACCP team member. This shall ensure that the risk of cross-contamination between species has been assessed and that suitable controls have been implemented.
Interpretation	Where it is the company's policy not to handle particular meat species to reduce the risk of cross-contamination between species, this needs to be understood in product development work (e.g. pork on sites producing halal products).

11.5 Product testing

The company shall have a species-testing programme based on risk and any specific customer requirements.

Clause	Requirements
11.5.1	There shall be a defined risk-based raw material and finished product testing programme to identify any cross-contamination between species, adulteration or fraud. Where specified by a customer, the frequency of testing shall meet the customer's requirement.
Interpretation	The frequency of testing shall consider risk and any claims made for raw materials or products (e.g. halal). Consideration in establishing the testing programme should include: • the opportunity for cross-contamination between species within the plant • the nature of the meat raw material (e.g. block frozen, minced) • the potential for cross-contamination between species at an earlier stage in the supply chain • the likelihood of the identification of any deliberate substitution • the results of the vulnerability assessment (clause 5.4.2 of the Standard).
11.5.2	Limits for acceptable and unacceptable test results shall be defined with regard to any legal or customer limits. Any out-of-specification results shall be investigated and action taken as appropriate to ensure that out-of-specification or illegal product is not placed on sale.
Interpretation	Wherever testing is carried out, acceptable or action limits must be established so that the results of the test can be interpreted. When defining control limits, reference should be made to the customer's requirements, legal limits and any relevant competent authority (e.g. Food Standards Agency in the UK). Any deviation from the procedures shall be investigated to establish the safety status and quality of the product to determine the action to be taken. It is important that the on-site personnel responsible for receiving and reviewing the laboratory tests are able to interpret the significance of the results and instigate any relevant actions (e.g. on receipt of a result exceeding the predefined acceptable limit).

11.6 Training

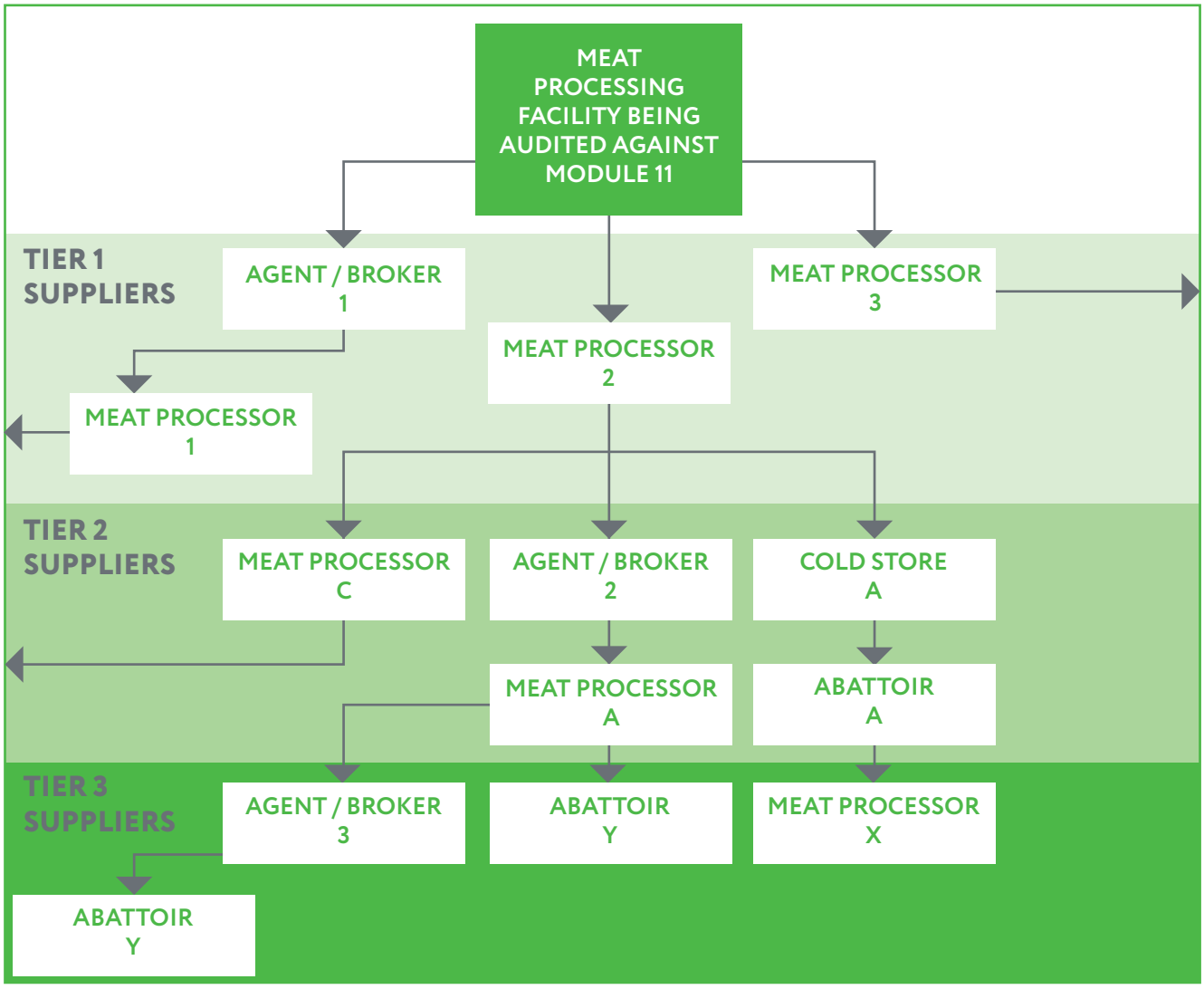
The company shall ensure that all personnel performing work that affects product safety, authenticity, legality and quality are demonstrably competent to carry out their activity through training, work experience or qualification.

Clause	Requirements
11.6.1	All relevant personnel, including non-production staff, agency-supplied staff, temporary staff and contractors, shall be appropriately trained on the importance of preventing cross-contamination between different meat species and any specific procedures relevant to their area of work.
Interpretation	Training in awareness of the requirements of the Module needs to be undertaken by all relevant staff, e.g.: hygiene team, engineers, procurement team. The processes must be understood not only by production staff but also by staff such as buyers who make decisions that could influence product authenticity.

Appendix 1

The relationship between the facility and their tiered suppliers

The diagram below shows the relationship between the facility being audited against Module 11 Meat Supply Chain Assurance and other suppliers in the supply chain where 3-year phased module implementation timeline is applicable.



BRCGS Food Safety

BRCGS
Floor 2
7 Harp Lane
London EC3R 6DP

T: +44 (0)20 3931 8150
E: enquiries@brcgs.com
W: brcgs.com
W: brcgsbookshop.com
W: brcgsparticipate.com

Part of LGC ASSURE